Brig KPN Singh was a hands-on kind of Commander, who liked to do most things himself. Whenever some letters came from the Div HQ asking for some comments or the other, he would jot down the outline reply on the reverse of the letter itself, which we then had to just flesh out into a cogent response. As a result, the DAA and QMG, Maj SS Randhawa and I, as the principal staff officers of the HQ, had a reasonably *khushi*, comfortable time. Brig KPN Singh being a simple person, had also passed orders that Tuesdays would be observed as dry days, meaning that liquor would not be served in the Officers' Mess. This restriction was easily overcome by having a couple of drinks in the room itself, before going to the Mess for dinner. I was to draw some very important lessons from that. The first was of observing an order or instruction in both 'letter and spirit'. We were all following the order in 'letter', but flouting the 'spirit' behind the order. The second was the futility of passing an order that was not implementable and going to be honoured more in the breach.

Brig KPN Singh was replaced by Brig Surat Singh Sandhu of the Artillery Regiment. The two were as different as chalk and cheese. Brig Sandhu was a total extrovert, liked his *sharab* and *kabab* (drinks and snacks) and was a keen golfer and outdoorsman. We were a bit shell-shocked by his arrival, and I think it showed in our countenance. Brig KPN Singh called Randhawa and me and gently explained the facts of life. You cannot choose your superiors or subordinates, he said, you have to work with all kinds of people, going on to add that the new Commander had the highest professional reputation. We should look past the surface, and as long as we were true to our profession, we had nothing to fear. Somewhat mollified, we bid Brig KPN Singh farewell and turned to our new Commander with the former's words ringing in our ears.

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